Last updated in November 2026

Shirley Cai

(615) 457-4745 shirley.cai@emory.edu scai5.github.io scai5

Research Interests

Health Economics, Labor Economics

Education

Emory University Atlanta, GA
Ph.D. in Economics *Spring 2027 (expected)*
M.S. in Economics *Summer 2026*

Stanford University Stanford, CA
M.S. in Statistics *Spring 2022*
B.A. in Economics *Spring 2022*

Job Market Paper

Medical School Environments and Physician Treatment Styles (with Ian McCarthy)
This paper studies the impact of medical school on treatment decisions where cardiologists have considerable discretion: the usage of cardiac catheterization in partial-blockage heart attack cases. Using a mover design, we find that a 10 percentage-point increase in cath lab exposure during training increases later catheterization usage by 0.58 percentage points. This effect is not mediated by medical school rank and, together with peer effects, compounds into a 1.67 long-run multiplier on per-cardiologist cath rates.

Working Papers

Formation of Physician Referral Networks: Drivers and Potential Consequences (with Ian McCarthy, Pablo Estrada, and Jillian Wilkins)

Works in Progress

Nurse Scope of Practice Expansions and Physician Location
This study seeks to understand whether existing primary care provider supply responds to expansion of nurse scope of practice (SOP), which allows advanced practice registered nurses (APRNs) to practice independently. Leveraging staggered state adoption of such policies, I find that neither aggregate primary care physician (PCP) location nor newly practicing PCP flows respond. Results show little evidence that SOP expansion induces physicians to leave markets due to increased competition; instead, it appears to allow APRNs to provide primary care without crowding out incumbent PCPs.

Publications

1. Eggleston, Karen, Toshiaki Iizuka, Yong Suk Lee, **Shirley Cai**, Rosina Lin, and Carter Nakamoto. 2026. "Nursing Home Staffing and Quality: Evidence from Japan." *Aging and Health Research* 6 (3): 100291.

Research Experience

Research Assistant to Dr. Matt Grennan, Emory University *Spring 2025 – Fall 2025*
Linked physician disciplinary action data to drug prescriptions and market exit

Research Assistant to Dr. Ian McCarthy, Emory University *Fall 2023 – Spring 2024*
Predicted physician race using name and location-based methods, and evaluated predictions using external test sets

Research Assistant to Dr. Karen Eggleston, Stanford University *Spring 2021 – Summer 2022*
Analyzed the relationship between staffing outcomes and quality of care in Japanese nursing homes

Research Assistant to Dr. Larry Goulder, Stanford University *Summer 2020*
Developed a projection model for pension fund dynamics

Teaching Experience

Instructor, ECON 101: Principles of Microeconomics *Spring 2026*
Course evaluations: 3.61 / 4.00

Teaching Assistant, ECON 372: Health Care Markets (Dr. Ian McCarthy) *Fall 2023, 2024, 2026*

Grader, ECON 201: Intermediate Microeconomics (Dr. Daniel Fershtman) *Spring 2024*

Conference Presentations

Southern Economics Association 96th Annual Meeting, Houston, TX *November 2026*

Professional Service

Organizer, Applied Microeconomics Graduate Student Reading Group *Fall 2024 – Summer 2025*

Technical Skills

Software: R, Python, Stata, LaTeX

References

Please request reference letters through the proxy ✉ **econjm@emory.edu**

Dr. Ian McCarthy, Committee Chair ✉ **immccar@emory.edu**
Associate Professor
Department of Economics, Emory University

Dr. Sara Markowitz, Committee Member ✉ **smarko2@emory.edu**
Professor
Department of Economics, Emory University

Dr. Matt Grennan, Committee Member ✉ **matthew.grennan@emory.edu**
Professor
Department of Economics, Emory University